Confined-space entry procedure

This procedure applies to every entry into valve chambers, wet wells and storage tanks at the Marlow Basin pumping stations. It must be read together with the site permit-to-work rules. Nobody enters a confined space alone, and nobody enters without a valid permit.

Equipment to check before entry

- Four-gas detector with a valid calibration label
- Full-body harness and retrieval tripod
- Portable blower with five metres of ducting
- Two-way radios, one for each team member
- First-aid kit and eye-wash bottle

Entry steps

1. Obtain a signed entry permit from the shift supervisor.
2. Isolate and lock out all pumps and valves that feed the chamber.
3. Ventilate the chamber with the portable blower for at least fifteen minutes.
4. Test the atmosphere at the top, middle and bottom of the chamber.
5. Record the readings on the permit and sign them.
6. Put on the harness and clip the retrieval line to the tripod.
7. Enter the chamber only while the standby person is at the opening.
8. Call the standby person by radio every ten minutes.
9. Leave the chamber immediately if the detector alarm sounds.

If the alarm sounds

Everyone leaves the chamber at once. The standby person does not go in to help; the casualty is lifted out with the retrieval line and the emergency services are called. Before anyone goes back in, repeat the atmosphere test described in step 4 and record the new readings on the permit.

Records

Completed permits are kept at the station office for five years. The site supervisor reviews them each month and reports any alarm events to the safety committee.

Training

Entrants and standby persons must hold a current confined-space certificate and take part in a rescue drill at least once a year.